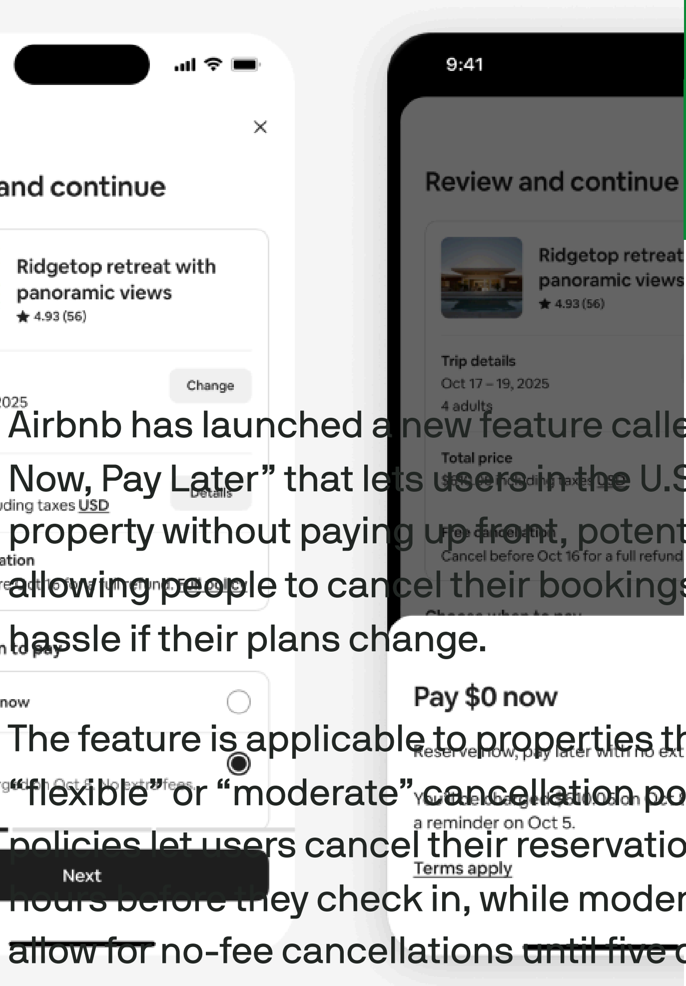
APPS

Airbnb will allow US users to book stays without paying up front

Ivan Mehta — 6:00 AM PDT · August 14, 2025



Airbnb has launched a new feature called "Reserve Now, Pay Later" that lets users in the U.S. reserve a property without paying up front, potentially allowing people to cancel their bookings with less hassle if their plans change.

The feature is applicable to properties that have a "flexible" or "moderate" cancellation policy. Flexible policies let users cancel their reservation up to 24 hours before they check in, while moderate policies allow for no-fee cancellations until five days before check-in.

IMAGE CREDITS: AIRBNB

Users will need to pay the full amount for their booking before the listing's free cancellation period ends. Airbnb will send users a reminder to pay before that date.

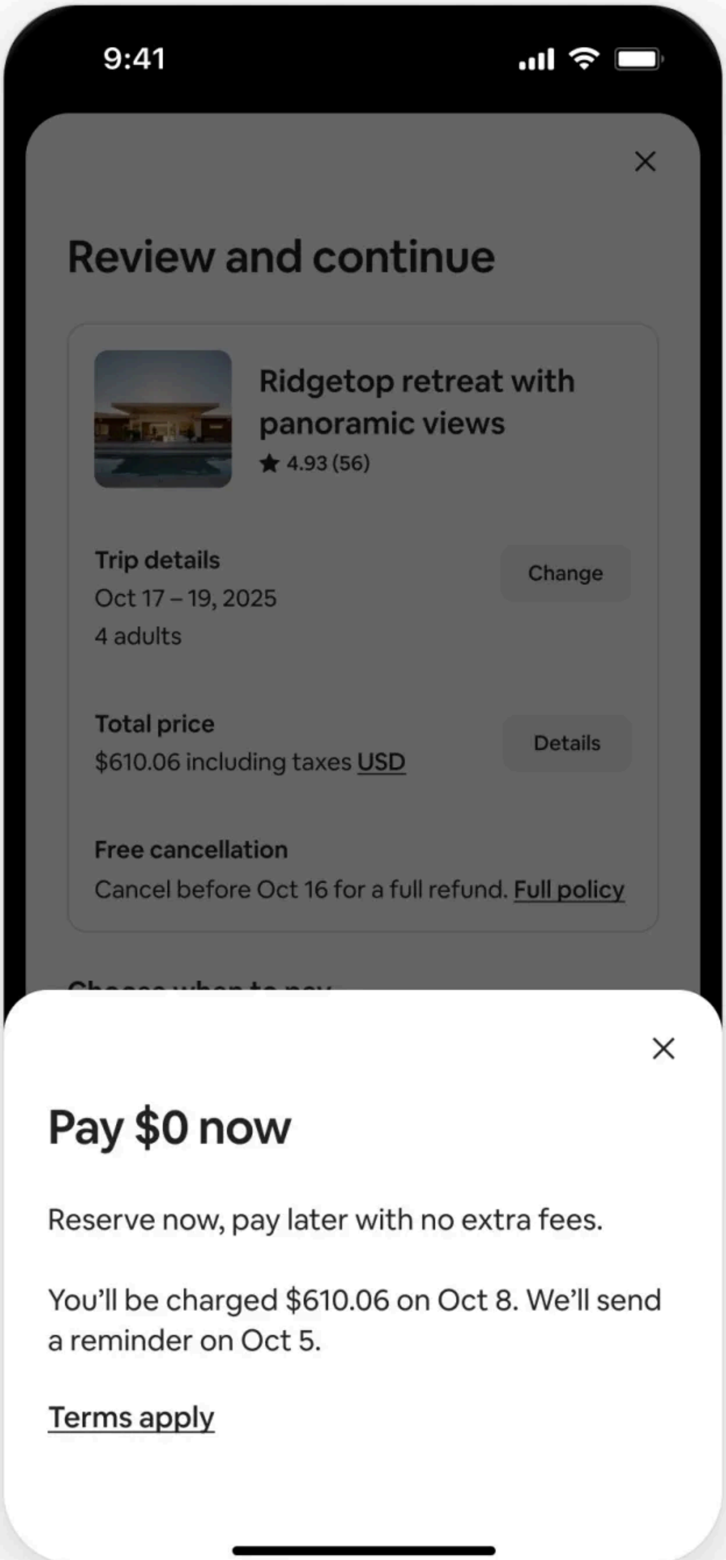


IMAGE CREDITS:AIRBNB

The company is not new to the buy now, pay later arena. In 2018, it launched a "Pay part now, part later" product that allowed users to pay either 20% or 50% in the first tranche and the rest later. In 2023, the company teamed up with Klarna to let users pay for their stays in four installments over six weeks.

Citing a survey it conducted with Focaldata, Airbnb said 55% of those surveyed preferred a flexible payment option while booking a stay, with 42% saying they missed out on properties while trying to figure out payment logistics with other travelers.

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out this survey to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: Airbnb Apps booking travel

Ivan Mehta

Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

View Bio

KEEP READING

STARTUPS

Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term "AI agents" was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

"I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing," Monaco told TechCrunch. "But it was actually a pain to maintain. There's so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs."

The result was Paradigm, an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google's Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

"We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs," Monaco said. "It's just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users."

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a $5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised $7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company's "extremely aggressive product roadmap."

"The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product," Monaco said. "I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it."

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. Quadratic, which has raised more than $6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

"What I'm seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future," Monaco said. "How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That's the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company."

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out this survey to let us know how *we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!*

Topics: AI AI artificial intelligence Enterprise enterprise startup Exclusive Fundraising fundraising General Catalyst startup startup fundraising Startups United States

Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | in

Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the...

View Bio >

KEEP READING

APPS

Substack writers can now direct US readers to (often cheaper) web-

based subscriptions on iOS

IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

Since then, a number of top apps have moved to offer in-app purchase links that point to their own websites, including Spotify, Patreon, and the Amazon Kindle app, among others.

In Substack's case, support for external payments will benefit both the company, which no longer has to pay the App Store a commission on those web sales, and consumers, who will have access to reduced pricing. Meanwhile, Substack creators will be able to offer their readers the option of whether they want the convenience of Apple's in-app payments system (IAP) or the web payment option, which is now accessible without having to leave the app.

Latest in Apps
See More

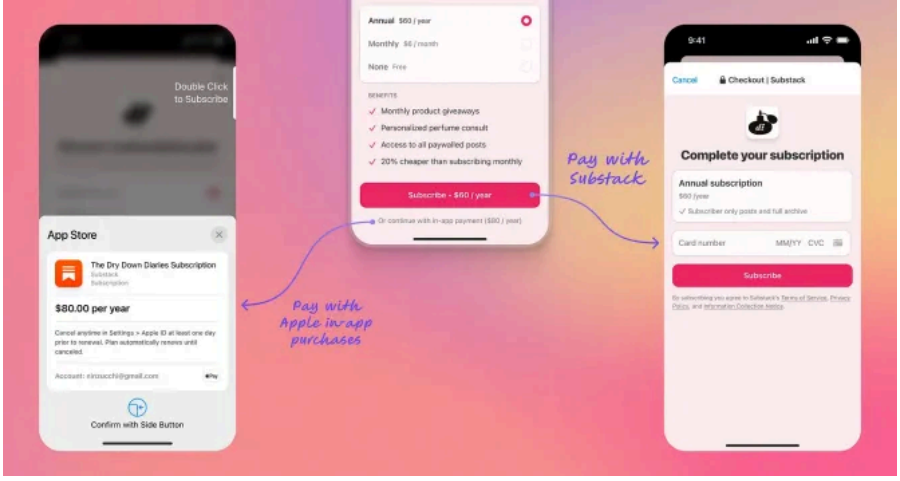


IMAGE CREDITS:SUBSTACK

Substack explains it will automatically adjust its customers' iOS app price higher to account for Apple's fees, allowing creators to take home the same amount of money as a web subscription. However, Substack writers can disable this feature if they choose. (Substack will continue to take its own 10% fee based on the web subscription price, as before.)

The company said in its blog post that it's also offering its writers "migration tools." We originally reported that these could help migrate users from one payments platform to another, but Substack reached out to correct this. Instead, it said that the tools are meant to help creators access billing information for Apple-managed subscriptions if they ever leave the platform.

Currently, more than 30,000 publications on the platform have in-app purchases enabled; Substack says early tests of the expanded set of payment options have driven a boost in paid sign-ups. It did not, however, share specific numbers related to this.

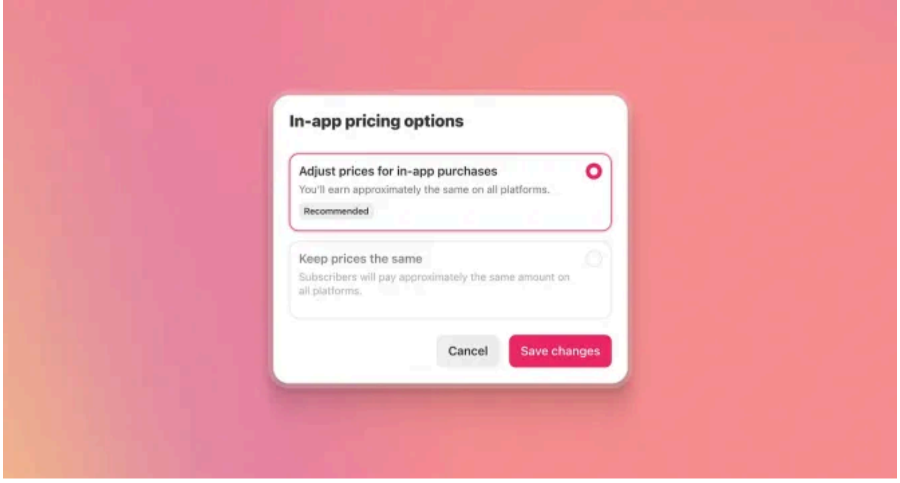


IMAGE CREDITS:SUBSTACK

The public launch of the external payments option will only impact new Substack subscriptions. Substack writers don't have to take any action unless they want to lower the prices for those using Apple's payments system.

Per Apple's App Store rules, fully opting out of offering IAP is not allowed.

While the changes impact the Substack app in the U.S., the company says it's still evaluating if it makes sense to switch to the more complex rules Apple offers in the EU and U.K. for developers who want to forgo IAP.

Updated after publication to correct and clarify how the migration tools work.

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out this survey to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: Apple Apps Apps iOS apps Substack

Sarah Perez
Consumer News Editor

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

View Bio

KEEP READING

IMAGE CREDITS:
ARTUR WIDAK/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

APPS

TikTok's latest feature lets college students find and connect with classmates

Aisha Malik — 6:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

In a move reminiscent of Facebook's early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the "Add school" button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

Users can then browse their school's page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

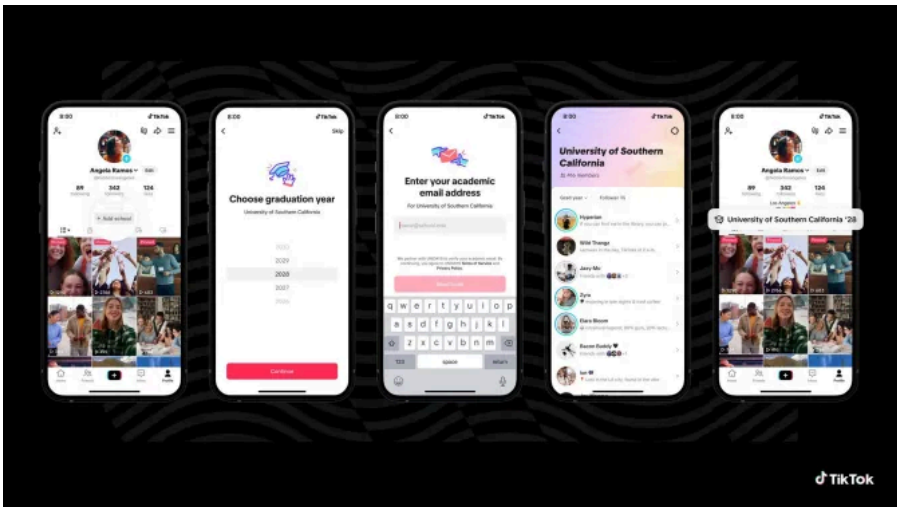


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok's partnership with UNiDAYS, a student verification platform that confirms student status.

TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook's original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok's new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.

It's worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was spotted testing a similar feature last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It's unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out this survey to let us know how *we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!*

Topics: Apps Social TikTok

Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

View Bio